

DISTRESS

The intensity of the sunlight was distressing. The shiny metal table reflected the light glaringly and Peggy, realising that she had left her sunglasses at home, could feel a headache coming on. If Shaun had been ready on time, they could have had a table under the trees, or one with an umbrella. He came back from placing their order, and took the chair opposite Peggy who folded her arms and pressed her lips together tightly.

- How do you think Peggy was feeling toward Shaun at that moment? Why do you say that?

COMPLICATED LESSON

Trevor had stood on this very spot with his father. He had listened earnestly to the patient explanation that these railway tracks were parallel lines. They went through town and country, transporting people, animals and freight. They would never meet, even if they continued to infinity. There were a lot of concepts that he had never mastered, so it was with a sense of pride that he was able to explain to his own grandson the complicated lesson of half a century ago.

- What complicated lesson did Trevor explain?

HARRY AND THE TIGER

The cold eyes of the tiger never left its prey. It made no sound. The pattern of its coat blended perfectly with the sun-speckled plants that it was creeping through. Another animal wouldn't know it was there until it was too late. It hadn't killed for a week now, and was hungry.

Just a few metres away, Harry was walking tiredly along the track. He had heard on the morning news something about a tiger on the loose somewhere but had only one thought on his mind - home. He was startled by the sounds of a car horn and voices coming from the road that ran alongside the track.

"Harry! It's not safe there! Get in!"

The tiger froze and watched as Harry disappeared from his view. It relaxed its muscles and turned back to the jungle.

- Do you think Harry knew the tiger was there? Why do you say that?
- How do you think the tiger felt as it turned back to the jungle? Why do you say that?

SANDWICH FILLINGS

Brian and John have been mates since the day they started school. They have always competed with each other.

They competed to see who could run, ride, jump, swim, climb, kick, throw or shoot the fastest, furthest or best. Brian's wife often said that if she had a dollar for every competition they had had over fifty years she would be a rich woman today.

Five years ago, they went with their wives to a beach resort. On the first morning they decided they would race to the island 500 metres offshore. Their wives put a stop to that and the talk of a tree climbing competition. On that day the two friends reluctantly agreed to give up competing in physically demanding activities. They spent the rest of the week competing at mini golf, pool and darts. They even timed each other to see who could do the dishes the fastest.

The men both taught at the local school. Their classes would always compete with each other in sports, debates and spelling bees. One lunchtime they listened in as two younger teachers talked about the unusual sandwich fillings some of their students had. That was all it took.

The following day Brian had salmon and peanut butter between two slices of white bread. John had grated carrot and cold porridge. The next day Brian had mushrooms and raspberry jam and John had rhubarb and baked beans. There were only two rules in the new competition: it must be an unusual filling and all of the sandwich had to be eaten.

On the fifth day Brian grinned as he peeled back the top slice of his sandwich to reveal the unusual, possibly unbeatable, filling: tinned herrings, cheese, hot mustard and thick, oozing custard.

Brian's face changed after the first bite. When he was halfway through eating it he had to rush down the hallway. When he returned John unwrapped his masterpiece. Between two thin slices of buttered bread was a slice of bread: a bread sandwich!

Brian raised his cup of coffee by way of a salute to the champion. The competition was over.

- How long ago do you think it was when the two friends started school? Why do you say that?
- Why do you think their wives put a stop to the swim to the island?
- Why do you think Brian rushed down the hallway?
- Why do you think the sandwich competition was over?

REACTION QUESTION

- Do you think John's bread sandwich was a fair choice for a filling? Why do you say that?